

The home of the bereaved Patel family at Dinguncha village in Kalol taluka of Gandhinagar district after news came of the deaths; (below) Road signage in Emerson, Manitoba, in Canada where the bodies of the Patel family were found metres from the US border



JOHN WOODS/AP

in Gujarat who in turn approached Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel seeking help in tracing them. The agents had taken these 15 people first to Mumbai and then to Kolkata. They were held hostage and tortured there. The agents took them to Delhi only after they received money from their family members. "The victims are in a very bad state mentally, physically and financially," says Mayur Chavda, the superintendent of police, Gandhinagar.

THE EXODUS

Jagdish, Vaishaliben and their two children were cremated in Canada on February 6 in a funeral crowdfunded by relatives in North America. A fortnight after the tragedy, the joint family home in Dingucha is still in shock. In a courtyard lined with wheat sacks, a small knot of friends and relatives have come to meet Jagdish's father, Baldev Patel. Jagdish worked as a supervisor at a garment unit in Kalol, 20 km from his village, but when the nationwide Covid lockdown was imposed in March 2020 ,he returned to farm wheat and castor oil seeds on the family's 15-acre farm. Maternal uncle Rajnikant Patel insists the story of his nephew and his family going to the US for work is false. "There was no dearth of money," he says. Yet what else would prompt a well-off family with an average annual income of Rs 15 lakh to pick their bags and travel to the US illegally?

Life for illegal immigrants is a nightmare in the US. They do not have the social security number which entitles US citizens to a job and other state benefits. Harold D'Souza, whose NGO Eyes Open International based in Cincinnati, Ohio, raises awareness on human trafficking, says victims are lured by false success stories. "Immigrants are misguided by agents about US citizenship and work culture," says D'Souza, a Vadodara native. "The employers promise them legal help in acquiring a green card, which rarely happens. The illegals can neither go back nor fight with their employers." While there is no data available on which Indian state sends out the most illegal immigrants, NGOs working in the field say Punjab heads the list with Gujarat next.

D'Souza estimates that illegal migration is a $150 billion industry in the US. Prosecutions happen in less than 10 per cent of cases. "No one likes to touch the agents as huge money is involved. I know several cases where illegal migrants were pushed into the flesh trade," he says. The influential Gujarati diaspora is also worried. "They (illegal immigrants) should remember that they will not be treated with honour if they come to the US illegally. No one should take the illegal route," says C.K. Patel, president of the California-based Vishwa Gujarati Samaj.

Activists like D'Souza believe travel agents are the masterminds and that the menace has to be halted at its source. Police could move in on the traffickers in Delhi only because the crimes committed came under the sections for extortion and cheating. Anil Pratham, DGP (women's security and crime), Gujarat Police, blames the US authorities. "We sent letters to authorities in the US and Canada seeking details of the Dingucha case. They did not respond," he says. "We can't do much if they are not complaining."

Yet there is evidence that gullible citizens continue to be targets. On February 5, Kalol resident Vishnu Patel filed a complaint with the police accusing Ahmedabad-based travel agent Rutvik Parekh of cheating. Patel had agreed to pay Rs 1.1 crore to Parekh to send nephew Vishal and his wife Rupani to the US via the Delhi-Mexico route (see *Dodgy Trails*). Patel alleges the agent started demanding the Rs 50 lakh advance even before the couple left India and that unknown persons shot at him at Parekh's behest.

With state elections due in December, politics has begun entering the picture. The Patels are politically very significant. They directly impact 45 of the state's 181 assembly seats and have influence in 35 others. Nitin Patel, a senior BJP leader and former deputy chief minister, said on January 21 in Mehsana that community members were leaving for the US because of a lack of employment opportunities in the state. A senior state government official rejects this allegation: "Our government has provided 200,000 government jobs in the past five years. We have a 10-year jobs plan ready. It is not true that there is a lack of opportunities."

What is true is that Patels feel left out and have been demanding reservations in government jobs since 2015. Last September, to appease the community, the BJP replaced CM Vijay Rupani, a Jain, with a first-time MLA, Bhupendra Patel. A Patel-centric human smuggling racket and the narrative of a job shortage in the state fuelling an exodus is a challenge for the new CM. With just 10 months left to go for polls, partymen hope he will crack down on such networks. Otherwise, the state's human pipeline will continue to gush migrants into the desolate frontiers of north America. ■